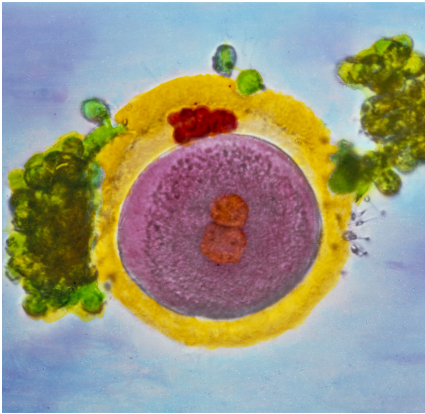




YOU ARE **2 WEEKS AND 2 DAYS**

264 days to go

WHAT'S HAPPENING INSIDE

Here a human egg cell 24 hours after fertilization is artificially colored purple. Around the egg is a thick layer (yellow) that has now become impenetrable. The two red areas, or pro-nuclei, contain genetic material from the mother and father before it has fused.

“When your egg has been fertilized, hormonal changes naturally occur to stop your normal menstrual cycle.”

At this early stage following fertilization of your egg, the developing embryo will signal its existence to the pituitary gland in your brain and switch off your menstrual cycle. It does this by producing a new hormone, called human chorionic gonadotropin (hCG). This hormone overrides your usual monthly cycle and maintains the high progesterone levels that are essential for your pregnancy. The hormone [progesterone](#) is essential to an embryo's survival in the uterus, and therefore to your baby's well-being and development before birth.

Later, starting around weeks four to five, your embryo will make all the hormones needed to maintain its own life. Of course its nourishment and shelter come from you, but even in the very early weeks of pregnancy the embryo behaves like an independent human, at least as far as its hormones and genes are concerned.

HEALTHY CONCEPTION

When you're trying to conceive, you'll find you are more aware of your general health. Colds, flu, and other common infections are unlikely to affect your fertility or your baby if you have conceived. Some infections and viruses, however, can have a more serious impact:

Shingles and chickenpox (both caused by the same virus) are best avoided around the time of conception if you haven't had chickenpox before.

Food poisoning, for example caused by listeria bacteria, can be harmful (see [Dietary precautions](#)).

Toxoplasmosis can be contracted from handling cat feces.

In low levels, testosterone may aid fertility, but too much can affect the menstrual cycle and lead to infertility. Small quantities of testosterone are secreted from the adrenal gland and the ovaries.

ASK A DOCTOR
